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Support pillow

Abstract

A support pillow including a backrest, a first armrest, and a second armrest. The first and second armrests are detachably engageable with the backrest. Together, the backrest and first and second armrests define and encircle a space into which a person's torso is received when the person is seated and resting against the backrest. A free end of the first armrest is detachably engageable with a free end of the second armrest a distance spaced longitudinally forward of a front of the backrest. Each of the backrest, first armrest, and second armrest may be provided with a handle and may include one or more pockets.

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Background/Summary

REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS (1) This application claims the benefit of U.S. Provisional Patent Application Ser. No. 63/321,811, filed Mar. 21, 1622, the entire disclosure of which is incorporated herein by reference.

TECHNICAL FIELD

(1) This disclosure is directed to seating aids. More particularly, the disclosure relates to a support pillow. Specifically, the disclosure is directed to a support pillow which provides comfortable back and arm support for a person when in a seated position and furthermore provides for support in front of the person's torso. The component parts of the support pillow are selectively detachably engageable with one another.

BACKGROUND ART

(2) Support pillows are used to help support parts of a person's body when in a seated position so that the person can sit comfortably without placing undue strain on their body. Elderly persons, people recovering from surgery, or anyone else who may want to sit more comfortably and securely

in an upright position can use a support pillow for such purposes.

(3) One support pillow proposed by the prior art is the Vekkia™ Standard Lightweight Bed Reading Pillow available on Amazon.com. This support pillow includes a wedge-shaped backrest having a front surface sculpted to provide improved lumbar and hip support. Two rectangular pieces of foam extend outwardly from the backrest and are provided to support a person's arms. A pillowcase for the support pillow is configured to receive all three foam pads, i.e., the backrest and the two arms. The parts of the pillowcase for the two arm pads are permanently attached to the part of the pillowcase which receives the backrest. When the three foam pads are installed within the pillowcase, the armrests project outwardly and forwardly from the backrest and at about 90° relative to the backrest's front surface.

(4) Another support pillow available on Amazon.com is the SLIGUY™ reading support pillow. Similar to the Vekkia™ support pillow referenced above, the Sliguy™ includes a backrest and two arms. The single pillowcase for the support pillow includes a region for the padded backrest and regions for the two arms. Instead of the armrests extending outwardly from the front surface of the backrest at about 90°, like the Vekkia™ pillow, in the Sliguy™ reading pillow the armrests flare outwardly away from one another moving in a direction away from the backrest's front surface. The pillow comes with a detachable neck roll which is secured to the part of the pillowcase which holds the backrest by button-type fasteners.

(5) Other types of support pillow are nursing pillows or breastfeeding pillows. Nursing pillows help a caregiver support an infant at a comfortable height while breastfeeding the infant or while feeding them with a bottle. The nursing pillow bears most of the weight of the infant thereon and therefore takes some of the strain of holding the infant off the caregiver's back, shoulders, and arms.

(6) A number of nursing pillows have been proposed in the prior art. For example, the BOPPY® Nursing Pillow and Positioner. (BOPPY® is a registered trademark of the Boppy Company, LLC. of Golden, Colorado, U.S.) The BOPPY® pillow is a C-shaped pillow that is placed on the caregiver's lap in such a way that the ends of the C-shape are adjacent the caregiver's waist and the body of the pillow rests on the caregiver's legs. The pillow is meant to help keep the baby at an appropriate and comfortable length for nursing. However, for taller caregivers, the pillow may not be sufficiently thick enough to support the baby at a comfortable nursing length. Additionally, the shape of the pillow is such that the weight of the baby tends to push the pillow away from the caregiver's body. The caregiver therefore has to constantly readjust the pillow's position in order to try and keep the baby close to the caregiver's body. In some embodiments, this tendency to push away from the body has been somewhat addressed by providing a strap that passes behind the caregiver's back and extends between the two ends of the C-shape of the pillow. The problem with the strap is that the caregiver has to use two hands to put the pillow into position around their body. The caregiver also needs two hands to remove the pillow. Caregivers sometimes only have one hand free and so it may be difficult if not impossible to engage or disengage the strap without putting the infant down. Another issue with this nursing pillow is that it has a rounded upper surface and this configuration tends to cause the infant to roll off the pillow away from the caregiver's body. It is therefore necessary that the caregiver pays careful attention to the location of the baby on the pillow so that they do not accidentally fall off the pillow.

SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

(7) A support pillow is disclosed herein which addresses some of the deficiencies of the prior art. The disclosed support pillow may be used in a variety of settings including but not limited to supporting elderly or infirm persons in a seated position, aiding those recovering from surgery, aiding caregivers while holding and/or feeding an infant, or simply to help a person sit more comfortably while reading or performing other tasks.

(8) The support pillow in accordance with the present disclosure may be discussed herein particularly in use as a nursing pillow but it will be understood that the disclosed support pillow may be used in a wide variety of other applications.

(9) In one aspect, an exemplary embodiment of the present disclosure may provide a support pillow comprising a backrest; a first armrest engageable with the backrest; a second armrest engageable with the backrest a lateral distance away from the first armrest; wherein each of the first armrest and the second armrest extends forwardly from the backrest and curves inwardly to terminate in a free end located a distance forwardly of a front of the backrest; wherein the free end of the first armrest is opposed to the free end of the second armrest; and wherein the backrest, the first armrest, and the second armrest, together, encircle a space adapted to receive a torso of a person therein.

(10) In one embodiment, the support pillow may further comprise a securement mechanism which detachably secures the free end of the first armrest to the free end of the second armrest. In one embodiment, one or both of the first armrest and the second armrest may be detachably engageable with the backrest. In one embodiment, the support pillow may further comprise a first securement mechanism for detachably securing one of the first armrest and the second armrest to the backrest. In one embodiment, the support pillow may further comprise a second securement mechanism for detachably securing the other of the first armrest and the second armrest to the backrest. In one embodiment, the backrest may have a depth measured between the front and a rear thereof, and wherein the depth tapers moving in a direction from a bottom of the backrest to a top of the backrest. In one embodiment, the front of the backrest may be oriented at an angle of from about 75° up to about 85° relative to a bottom of the backrest. In one embodiment, a rear of the backrest may be oriented at 90° relative to a bottom of the backrest. In one embodiment, the support pillow may further comprise a handle provided on the backrest.

(11) In one embodiment, the first armrest and the second armrest may be substantially identical to one another and may be arranged as mirror images of one another relative to the backrest. In one embodiment, each of the first armrest and the second armrest may have a top end, a bottom end, a front end, and a rear end; wherein each of the first armrest and the second armrest is of a height measured between the top end and the bottom end thereof; and wherein the height may taper moving in a direction from the rear end of the first armrest and the second armrest to the front end thereof. In one embodiment, the top end of each of the first armrest and the second armrest may be oriented at an angle of from about 75° up to about 85° relative to the rear end thereof. In one embodiment, the rear end of the first armrest and the second armrest may be oriented at 90° relative to the bottom end thereof. In one embodiment, the support pillow may further comprise a handle provided on one or both of the first armrest and the second armrest. In one embodiment, a rear end of each of the first armrest and the second armrest may be oriented at an angle of from about 190° up to about 210° relative to a back of the backrest. In one embodiment, each of the first armrest and the second armrest may be generally J-shaped. In one embodiment, each of the first armrest and the second armrest may be of a width proximate a rear end thereof, wherein the rear end is located proximate a back of the backrest, and wherein the width tapers moving from the rear end towards a front end thereof. In one embodiment, the support pillow may further comprise one or more pockets provided on one or more of the backrest, the first armrest, and the second armrest.

(12) In one aspect, an exemplary embodiment of the present disclosure may provide a method comprising detachably engaging a first end of a first armrest with a backrest of a support pillow; detachably engaging a first end of a second armrest with the backrest a laterally-spaced distance from the first end of the first armrest; placing a second end of the first armrest in close proximity to a second end of the second armrest a distance longitudinally forwardly of a front of the backrest; and encircling a space with the backrest, the first armrest, and the second armrest; wherein the space is adapted to receive a torso of a person resting against the backrest. In one embodiment, the method may further comprise detachably engaging the second end of the first armrest to the second end of the second armrest.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- (1) Sample embodiments of the present disclosure are set forth in the following description, are shown in the drawings and are particularly and distinctly pointed out and set forth in the appended claims.
- (2) FIG. 1 is a front, top, right side perspective view of a first embodiment of a support pillow in accordance with an aspect of the present disclosure;
- (3) FIG. 2 is an exploded front, top, right side perspective view of the support pillow shown in FIG. 1;
- (4) FIG. 3 is a right side elevation of the support pillow of FIG. 1;
- (5) FIG. 4 is a rear elevation view of the support pillow of FIG. 1;
- (6) FIG. 5 is a top plan view of the support pillow of FIG. 1;
- (7) FIG. 6A is a front, top, right side perspective view of a first operational view of the support pillow in accordance with the present disclosure being used to support the body of a mother while nursing their infant; and
- (8) FIG. 6B is a front, top, right side perspective view of a second operational view of the support pillow in use and showing one of the armrests disengaged from the backrest and a person comfortably seated and supported thereby.
- (9) Similar numbers refer to similar parts throughout the drawings.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

- (10) Referring to FIGS. 1 and 2 there is shown a support pillow in accordance with the present disclosure, generally indicated at **10**. Support pillow **10** comprises a backrest **12**, a first armrest **14**, and a second armrest **16**. Each of the backrest **12**, first armrest **14**, and second armrest **16** are fabricated as separate, individual components which are able to be selectively detachably engaged with one another as will be described later herein.
- (11) Backrest **12** is a separate cushion which has a front **12a**, a rear **12b** (FIGS. 3 and 4), a top **12c**, a bottom **12d** (FIGS. 2 and 4), a left side **12e**, and a right side **12f**. The terms “front”, “rear”, “top”, “bottom”, “left” and “right” are used to refer to the way the support pillow **10** is illustrated in the attached drawings. These descriptive terms are also to be understood from the manner in which the support pillow **10** will be regarded from the perspective of a person seated with their back resting against the backrest **12**, their right arm resting on the first armrest **14** (or right armrest), and their left arm resting on the second armrest **16** (or left armrest) of the support pillow **10**.
- (12) Front **12a** is opposed to and spaced a distance from rear **12b** and defines a longitudinal direction therebetween. Top **12c** is opposed to and spaced a distance from bottom **12d** and defines a vertical direction therebetween. Left side **12e** is opposed to and spaced a distance apart from right side **12f** and defines a lateral direction therebetween. The left side **12e** and right side extend between the front **12a** and the rear **12b**, and between the top **12c** and bottom end **12d**. The longitudinal direction, vertical direction, and lateral direction are arranged at 90° relative to one another.
- (13) Although not illustrated herein, it will be understood that backrest **12** is comprised of an interior foam core and an external cover (or pillowcase) which envelopes the interior core. The interior core may be made from any suitable cushioning materials which are safe for human use. In particular, the interior foam core may be made from a suitable cushioning material which is safe for use with infants. In some embodiments, the core may be comprised of foam in combination with filler materials. In one embodiment, for example, a plastic insert may be surrounded by foam material to form the interior core. The plastic insert may be used to reduce the overall costs of manufacture of the support pillow's backrest **12**. (It will be understood that the first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** may be similarly fabricated.) The interior core is inserted into the external cover which preferably is selectively removable from the core for cleaning. In particular, the cover may be made from a fabric that is able to be washed in a washing machine and dried in a dryer without

shrinking or fading. The cover may include any suitable closure mechanisms to retain it around the core. The closure mechanisms may include but are not limited to a zipper, snap fasteners, tie closures, and buttons. In one embodiment the interior core may be fabricated from a material that is able to be washed and dried in a similar manner to the cover. In other embodiments, the cover may be permanently engaged around the interior core and is not removable for laundering. In these other embodiments, the cover may be treated to resist stains and may further be treated to be water resistant. In yet other embodiments, the entire backrest **12**, i.e., the interior core and external cover may be made from suitable materials which enable the backrest **12** as a unit to be laundered in a washer and dryer.

(14) As best seen in FIGS. **2** and **3**, backrest **12** is a wedge-shaped component which is of a first depth “**D1**” measured between front **12a** and rear **12b** proximate top **12c**. Backrest **12** is furthermore of a second depth “**D2**” measured between front **12a** and rear **12b** proximate bottom **12d**. Depth “**D2**” is greater than depth “**D1**”. As a consequence, the depth of backrest **12** tapers in a direction moving from bottom **12d** towards top **12c**. Rear **12b** is oriented at 90° relative to bottom **12d** of backrest **12**. Front **12a** of backrest **12** is oriented at an acute angle α relative to bottom **12d**. In one embodiment, the angle α is between 75° and 85° relative to bottom **12d**. It will be understood, however, that in other embodiments, the angle α may be smaller than 75° or slightly larger than 85° but preferably less than 90°. Because of the presence of the angle α , a person reclining against backrest **12** will have the lower portion of the backrest **12** supporting their lower back and the upper portion of the backrest **12** angling backwardly so that the person resting against the backrest will be able to relax but not fully recline or sit bolt upright. FIGS. **1** and **3** show the backrest **12** in an orientation where the wider bottom end of the wedge shape will be located so as to generally align with a person's lower back and buttocks. In this arrangement, when a person is resting against the front **12a** of backrest **12**, the angular orientation of front **12a** will enable the seated person to remain generally upright will still being reclined against the backrest **12** at a gentle and comfortable angle.

(15) Referring particularly to FIG. **2**, it can be seen that first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** are substantially identical in configuration to one another and are arranged relative to backrest **12** as mirror images of one another.

(16) First armrest **14** is a separate cushion which includes a front end **14a** opposed to and spaced a distance from a rear end **14b**. Front end **14a** and rear end **14b** (FIGS. **3** and **4**) define a longitudinal direction therebetween. First armrest **14** further includes a top end **14c** opposed to and spaced a distance from a bottom end **14d** (FIG. **3**). Top end **14c** and bottom end **14d** define a vertical direction therebetween. An outer side **14e** is opposed to and spaced apart from an inner side **14f**. Outer side **14e** and inner side **14f** define a lateral direction therebetween. Outer side **14e** and inner side **14f** extend between front end **14a** and rear end **14b**, and between top end **14c** and bottom end **14d**. A region of the first armrest **14** proximate the rear end **14b** comprises a first end of the first armrest **14**. A region of the first armrest **14** remote from the rear end **14b** and proximate the front end **14a**, particularly adjacent the inner side **14f** comprises a second end of the first armrest **14**. The second end may also be referred to herein as the “free end” of the first armrest **14**. The first end of the first armrest **14** is detachably engageable with the backrest **12**, as will be described later herein. The second end of the first armrest **14** is configured for detachable engagement with the second armrest **16**, as will be later described herein.

(17) Similarly, second armrest **16** is a separate cushion and has a front end **16a** opposed to and spaced a distance from a rear end **16b** (FIG. **4**). Front end **16a** and rear end **16b** define a longitudinal direction therebetween. Second armrest **16** further includes a top end **16c** opposed to and spaced a distance from a bottom end **16d** (FIG. **4**). Top end **16c** and bottom end **16d** define a vertical direction therebetween. An outer side **16e** of second armrest **16** is opposed to and spaced apart from an inner side **16f** thereof. Outer side **16e** and inner side **16f** define a lateral direction therebetween. The outer side **16e** and inner side **16f** extend between front end **16a** and rear end

16b, and between top end **16c** and bottom end **16d**. A region of second armrest **16** proximate rear end **16b** comprises a first end of second armrest **16**. A region of second armrest **16** remote from rear end **16b** and proximate front end **16a** thereof, particularly adjacent inner side **16f**, comprises a second end of second armrest **16**. The second end may also be referred to herein as the “free end” of second armrest **16**. The first end of second armrest **16** is detachably engageable with backrest **12** in a location generally opposite where the first end of the first armrest **14** engages backrest **12**. The second end of the second armrest **16** is configured for detachable engagement with first armrest **14**, as will be later described herein.

(18) Although not illustrated herein, it will be understood that first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** may be fabricated from substantially similar materials and in a similar manner to backrest **12**. As such, first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** may include an interior foam core and a removable outer cover. Because the construction of first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** is substantially similar to that of backrest **12**, the construction thereof will not be further discussed herein for the sake of brevity.

(19) FIG. 3 shows that backrest **12** is of a first height “H1” measured between top **12c** and bottom **12d** thereof. As mentioned earlier herein, first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** are substantially identical in construction but are arranged as mirror images of one another relative to backrest **12**. Each of the first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** is of a first height “H2” proximate the respective rear end **14b**, **16b** and is of a second height “H3” proximate the respective front end **14a**, **16a**. The heights “H2” and “H3” are measured between the top end **14c**, **16c**, and bottom end **14d**, **16d** of the respective one of the first armrest **14** and second armrest **16**. In other words, the configuration of the armrests **14**, **16** is such that they taper in height moving in a direction from rear end **14b**, **16b** through to front end **14a**, **16a** thereof. Top end **14c**, **16c** is oriented at an acute angle β (FIG. 3) relative to the respective rear end **14b**, **16b**. The acute angle is from about 75° up to about 85°. Rear end **14b**, **16b** is oriented at 90° relative to bottom end **14d**, **16d**, of the respective armrests **14**, **16**. Height “H1” of backrest **12** is greater than either of the first height “H2” or second height “H3” of first and second armrests **14**, **16**.

(20) Armrests **14**, **16** are configured to rest upon the thighs of a user. The tapered configuration of the armrests **14**, **16** helps to ensure that when a user places the bottom ends **14d**, **16d** of the armrests **14**, **16** on their thighs by lifting the armrests **14**, **16** upwardly (as shown in phantom in FIG. 3), the top ends **14c**, **16c** of the armrests will tend to be generally horizontally oriented. When the armrests are not on the person's thighs, the top end **14c**, **16c** angles downwardly as shown in solid lines in FIG. 3. The tapered profile of armrests **14**, **16** helps to ensure that a person's armrests are able to be rested comfortably on the top end **14c**, **16c** in a natural position. If the armrests **14**, **16** were of a constant height from front to back then a person's armrests could be held at a less natural and therefore more uncomfortable position. If the pillow **10** were being used by a parent or caregiver to support an infant thereon, the armrests **14**, **16** resting on the parent's thighs will tend to gently roll the infant towards the body of the parent or caregiver at a natural height instead of lifting the infant too high and causing a sharp roll of the child towards the caregiver's body. The possible raising and lowering of the front ends of the armrests **14**, **16** is indicated by arrow “A” in FIG. 3.

(21) FIG. 5 shows that rear **12b** of backrest **12** is substantially straight or planar from left side **12e** to right side **12f**. When pillow **10** is assembled, as shown in FIGS. 1 and 5, the rear end **14b** of first armrest **14** angles outwardly and forwardly at an angle Θ relative to the rear **12b** of backrest **12**. Similarly, the rear end **16b** of second armrest **16** angles outwardly and forwardly at the same angle Θ relative to the rear **12b** of backrest **12**. In one embodiment, the angle Θ is from about 190° up to about 210°. FIG. 5 shows the angle Θ at 200° relative to rear **12b** of backrest **12**.

(22) FIGS. 2 and 5 show that each of the first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** is generally J-shaped in configuration and includes a first leg and a second leg that are oriented generally at a right angle to one another. Because first and second armrests **14**, **16** are arranged as mirror images

of one another in pillow **10**, when the assembled pillow **10** is viewed from above, as in FIG. 5, the first armrest **14** is of an inverted J-shape and the second armrest **16** is J-shaped.

(23) Referring still to FIG. 5, the first leg of each armrest **14**, **16** extends forwardly and inwardly from an outermost end of the respective rear section **14c**, **16c**. The outermost end of rear section **14c**, **16c** is that region which is remote from backrest **12**. The second leg of each armrest **14**, **16** extends outwardly from the first leg thereof and is oriented generally parallel to front **12a** of backrest **12**. The outer side **14e**, **16e** joins the outermost end of the respective rear end **14b**, **16b** at a curved first corner **14g**. Each outer side **14e**, **16e** is comprised of a first section **14e'**, **16e'** and a second section **14e''**, **16e''** which meet at a curved second corner **14h**, **16h**. The first section **14e'**, **16e'** extends forwardly and inwardly from the curved first corner **14g**, **16g** and the second section **14e''**, **16e''** extends further forwardly and inwardly from curved second corner **14h**, **16h**, respectively. Each of the first section **14e'**, **16e'** and second section **14e''**, **16e''** is generally straight along its length. Second section **14e''**, **16e''** joins front end **14a**, **16a**, respectively at a curved third corner **14j**, **16j**. The inner side **14f**, **16f** is of an inverted J-shape (for first armrest **14**) and a J-shape (for second armrest **16**.)

(24) Because of the configuration of outer side **14e**, **16e** relative to inner side **14f**, **16f**, the first leg of each of the first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** is of a greater first width "W1" proximate rear end **14b**, **16b** and narrows in width moving forwardly towards front end **14a**, **16a**. Where second leg extends outwardly from first leg, the width of the first leg is indicated as the second width "W2". The width "W2" is less than the width "W1". The inverted J-shape of first armrest **14** is further formed by providing an end face **14k** which extends between inner side **14f** and front end **14a**. Similarly, the J-shaped of second armrest **16** is further formed by providing an end face **16k** which extends between inner side **16f** and front end **16a**. End face **14k** is oriented at a right angle relative to front end **14a**. Similarly, end face **16k** is oriented at a right angle relative to front end **16a**. End face **14k** and end face **16k** are opposed to one another and are configured to abut one another. The location where end faces **14k**, **16k** meet is located a distance longitudinally forward of front **12a** of backrest.

(25) Referring to FIG. 5, inner side **14f** of first armrest **14** includes a first section **14f'**, a second section **14f''**, and a third section **14f'''**. First section **14f'** is substantially straight and is configured to extend along second side **12f** of backrest **12** and to remain in close abutting contact therewith. Second section **14f''** is an elongate arcuate region of first armrest **14** which extends forwardly from first section **14f'**. Third section **14f'''** extends inwardly from second section **14f''** and is substantially straight. Third section **14f'''** intersects with end face **14k** in such a way that third section **14f'''** and end **14k** are oriented at 90° to one another. Similarly, inner side **16f** of second armrest **16** includes a first section **16f'**, a second section **16f''**, and a third section **16f'''**. First section **16f'** is substantially straight and is configured to extend along first side **12e** of backrest **12** and to remain in close abutting contact therewith. Second section **16f''** is an elongate arcuate region of second armrest **16** which extends forwardly from first section **16f'**. Third section **16f'''** extends inwardly from second section **16f''** and is substantially straight. Third section **16f'''** intersects with end face **16k** in such a way that third section **16f'''** and end **16k** are oriented at 90° to one another.

(26) Referring still to FIG. 5, first section **14f'** of first armrest **14** and first section **16f'** of second armrest **16** are spaced laterally from one another. The lateral distance between first section **14f'** and first section **16f'** is substantially equal to the width "W3" of backrest **12**. Second sections **14f''** and **16f''** gradually curve inwardly towards one another moving in a direction outwardly away from front **12a** of backrest **12**. The space **34** encircled by front **12a** of backrest **12** and first and second armrests **14**, **16** narrows to a width "W4" proximate third sections **14f'''** and **16f'''** of the two armrests **14**, **16**. Space **34** is of a length "L" measured between front **12a** of backrest **12** and third sections **14f'''** and **16f'''**. The straight third sections **14f'''** and **16f'''** are oriented substantially parallel to front **12a** of backrest **12** and are substantially laterally aligned with one another.

(27) The torso of a person using support pillow **10** is received within space **34**. It will be

understood that the inner side **14f**, **16f** of the first leg of each of the first armrest **14** and second armrest is configured to extend comfortably along the sides of the person's torso when they are seated with their back resting on backrest **12**. In this position, the second legs of each of the first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** curve in front of the person's abdomen. The end faces **14k**, **16k** face one another and abut one another.

(28) Referring now to FIGS. **4** and **2**, a first securement mechanism **18** is provided to secure first armrest **14** to backrest **12** and a second securement mechanism **20** is provided to secure second armrest **16** to backrest **12**. Any suitable type of securement mechanism can be used for this purpose. The attached figures, however, show a quick release buckle assembly being used as first securement mechanism **18** and second securement mechanism **20**. The first securement mechanism **18** includes a buckle **18a** secured via a strap **18a'** to rear **12b** of backrest **12**. First securement mechanism **18** further includes a housing **18b** secured via a strap **18b'** to rear end **14b** of first armrest **14**. The buckle **18a** may, instead, be secured to first armrest **14** and the housing **18b** may be secured to backrest **12**. Second securement mechanism **20** is of a substantially identical configuration to first securement mechanism **18** and therefore won't be described in further detail. Quick release buckle assemblies and their operation are well known and therefore won't be described in any further detail herein.

(29) First armrest **14** and second armrest **16** are individually detachably secured to backrest **12** via the first securement mechanism **18** and second securement mechanism **20**. If only one armrest is desired to be engaged with backrest **12**, then only that desired armrest will be secured to backrest **12**. If both armrests **14**, **16** are desired to be engaged with backrest **12**, then both armrests will be secured thereto by the appropriate first and second securement mechanisms **18**, **20**. If armrests **14**, **16** are engaged with backrest **12** and the user wishes to detach both armrests **14**, **16**, the user simply has to disengage both buckles (such as buckle **18a**) from their associated housing **18b**.

(30) Although not illustrated herein, it will be understood that, provided the first and second securement mechanisms **18**, **20** are arranged on backrest **12** as mirror images of one another, it is possible to engage second armrest **16** with backrest **12** in the location occupied by first armrest **14**, i.e., proximate right side **12f** instead of proximate left side **12e**. In this instance the armrests **14**, **16** would not encircle a user's torso but would instead angle outwardly away from the user's legs. This particular arrangement of the armrests **14**, **16** relative to the backrest **12** would be selected if the user desired to use the pillow in a different manner.

(31) FIG. **1** shows that a third securement mechanism **22** is provided to selectively and adjustably secure first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** to one another. The third securement mechanism **22** is also illustrated as being a quick release buckle assembly identical to first securement mechanism **18**. Third securement mechanism **22** includes a buckle **22a** secured to front end **14a** of first armrest **14** via a strap **22a'** and a housing **22b** secured to front end **16a** of second armrest **16** via a strap **22b'**. (The buckle **22a** could, instead, be secured to the second armrest **16** and the housing **22b** could be secured to the first armrest **14**. The third securement mechanism **22** is within easy reach of a person sitting with their back against the backrest **12**. If it is desired to secured first armrest **14** to second armrest **16** such that the two end faces **14k**, **16k** do not move away from one another during use, then third securement mechanism **22** will be utilized to secure the armrests to one another. If the person no longer wishes the two armrests **14**, **16** to be locked in place around their torso, they will simply disengage the buckle **22a** from housing **22b**.

(32) It will be understood that other types of securement mechanism can be utilized on pillow **10** in place of one or more of the quick release buckle assemblies **18**, **20**, **22** shown in the attached figures. For example, the quick release buckle assemblies **18**, **20**, **22** could be replaced with hook and loop fastener strips or with straps that include snaps or buttons and button holes.

(33) Support pillow **10** includes a handle on each of backrest **12**, first armrest **14**, and second armrest **16**. Handle **24** (FIG. **4**) is provided on rear **12b** of backrest **12**; handle **26** is provided on first armrest **14**; and handle **28** (FIG. **5**) is provided on second armrest **16**. The handle **24** may be

placed at any location on support pillow **10** such as, but not limited to, an upper portion of the rear **12b** thereof. Similarly, the handle **26** may be placed at any location on first armrest **14** such as, but not limited to, the first section **14e'** of outer side **14e**. Similarly, the handle **28** may be placed at any location on second armrest **16** such as, but not limited to, the first section **16e'** of outer side **16e**. Handles **24**, **26**, **28** are provided to enable a user to carry the entire support pillow **10** or one of the parts thereof, i.e., the backrest **12**, first armrest **14**, or second armrest **16**.

(34) One or more pockets are provided on support pillow **10**. The attached figures show a pocket **30** provided on first armrest **14** and a pocket **32** provided on second armrest **16**. Pocket **30** is illustrated as being located on second section **14e''** of outer side **14e** of first armrest **14**. Similarly, pocket **32** is illustrated as being located on second section **16e''** of outer side **16e** of second armrest **16**. It will be understood, however, that pockets **30**, **32** may be of any desired configuration and at any desired location on the associated armrest **14**, **16**. Pockets **30**, **32** are suitably shaped and sized to receive objects such as a cellphone, tablet, books, eyeglasses, baby bottles etc. Pockets **30**, **32** may be fabricated from the same material as the associated first armrest **14** or second armrest **16**, or may be fabricated from a different material, such as a mesh fabric. It will further be understood that one or more pockets may additionally or alternatively be provided on backrest **12**. For example, a pocket may be provided on rear **12b** of backrest **12** or on either of the left side **12e** or right side **12f**.

(35) Referring now to FIGS. **1** through **6B**, the assembly and use of support pillow **10** will be described. In a first assembly step, the first armrest **14** is engaged with the backrest **12** by securing the first securement mechanism **18**. Similarly, the second armrest **16** is engaged with the backrest **12** by securing the second securement mechanism **20**. When support pillow **10** is fully assembled, as illustrated in FIG. **1**, then backrest **12**, first armrest **14**, and second armrest **16** together bound and define a space **34**.

(36) The support pillow **10** is then placed on a surface upon which a user will be seated while using support pillow **10**. FIG. **6A** shows a first operational position of support pillow **10**. The figure shows the support pillow **10** placed on a couch "C" in such a way that the rear **12b** of backrest **12** abuts a front surface of a couch cushion "CC". The bottom **12d** of backrest **12** rests on the couch seat "CS". A mother of an infant is shown seated on the couch seat "CS" with her back resting against the front **12a** of backrest **12**. The first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** are engaged with backrest **12** and have been lifted up to rest upon the mother's thighs. The third securement **22** has been used to secure first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** to one another. This arrangement makes it comfortable for the mother to rest her right arm on the top end **14c** of the first armrest **14** and to rest her left arm on the top end **16c** of the second armrest **16**. It should be noted that the mother's body is located within the space **34** (FIG. **1**) defined by backrest **12**, first armrest **14**, and second armrest **16**. The backrest **12**, first armrest **14**, and second armrest **16** encircle the mother's torso. The abutting end faces **14k**, **16k** of the two armrests **14**, **16** are located in front of the mother's abdomen. An infant is illustrated as being held in the mother's left arm with infant's body resting comfortably on the top ends **14c**, **16c** of the first and second armrests **14**, **16**. Obviously, the mother can readily reposition the infant so that they are cradled in their mother's right arm and with their body being comfortably supported on the top ends **16c**, **14c** of the armrests **14**, **16**. The first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** are arranged so that the top ends **14c**, **16c**, respectively, are relatively flat. The configuration helps to ensure that there is less likelihood of the infant accidentally rolling off the first armrest **14** and second armrest **16**. The configuration of the armrests **14**, **16** also helps to distribute the weight of the baby relatively easily over the mother's lap.

(37) Obviously, instead of being used while breastfeeding, support pillow **10** provides a comfortable setting for nursing a baby with a bottle or simply cradling an infant or young child. Support pillow **10** is also useful for providing a comfortable setting for a mother to pump breast milk. Support pillow **10** not only provides a comfortable position for the mother's armrests to rest but the relatively flat top ends **14c**, **16c** of first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** provide a sufficiently stable enough platform upon which to rest the equipment needed while pumping breast

milk.

(38) It is quite easy for the mother to disengage the third securement mechanism **22** between the first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** with one hand when she needs to get up from the couch “C” but still has the infant in their arms. The third securement mechanism **22** may be disengaged simply by depressing the appropriate parts of the buckle **22a**. Disengaging the third securement mechanism **22** allows the free ends of the armrests to move apart from one another and the mother can stand up relatively unimpeded by the armrests **14, 16**.

(39) FIG. **6B** illustrates a situation where the second armrest **16** has been detached from backrest **12** (by disengaging the second securement mechanism **20**). The first armrest **18** remains engaged with backrest **12** and a person is shown seated on the couch seat “CS” with her back abutting front **12a** of backrest **12** and her right arm resting comfortably on first armrest **14**.

(40) Each of the backrest **12**, first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** may be detached from support pillow **10** and be used on their own. It will be understood that because the first armrest **14** and second armrest **16** are identical to one another, either arm can be engaged on either side of the backrest **12**; the arm in question simply needs to be flipped over to assume the correct orientation for engagement with the backrest **12**. Pockets can be provided accordingly on first and second armrests **14, 16** so that some pockets open towards top end **14c, 16c** and others open towards bottom end **14d, 16d**.

(41) It will be understood that support pillow **10** may be used in other settings such as in a bed (for a person recovering from illness or surgery) or even on a floor surface where there is no support for the backrest **12**. Support pillow **12** can also be used in settings, such as on a floor or carpet, where the backrest **12** will then provide sufficient support for the user to be seated comfortably while feeding a baby, for example.

(42) It will be understood that in other embodiments not illustrated herein, the first armrest and second armrest may be permanently secured to the backrest to form a single, unitary component. The free ends of the first armrest and second armrest may still be detachably securable to one another to encircle the torso of the user. The resultant support pillow will be used in an identical manner to support pillow **10** as described earlier herein except with respect to adjustability functions that are not possible because of the configuration of the component parts of this alternative embodiment.

(43) In yet other embodiments not illustrated herein, only one of the two armrests may be integrally connected with the backrest to form a single unitary component. The other of the two armrests may be detachably engageable with the backrest. The permanently attached armrest and the detachable armrest will still be able to be selectively engaged with one another via a securement mechanism to hold the two end faces of the armrests in abutting contact with one another. The resultant support pillow will be used in an identical manner as described earlier herein except with respect to adjustability functions that are not possible because of the configuration of the component parts of this alternative embodiment.

(44) In summary, a method is disclosed which includes providing a support pillow **10** having a backrest **12** with a front **12a**, a rear **12b**, a top **12c**, a bottom **12d**, and left and right sides **12e, 12f** extending from the front **12a** to the back **12b**, and from the top **12c** to the bottom **12d**. The method further includes engaging a first end of a first armrest **14** with the backrest **12** via a first securement mechanism **18** and engaging a first end of a second armrest **16** with the backrest **12** via a second securement mechanism **20**. The first end of the first armrest **14** is located on the backrest **12** generally laterally opposite the first end of the second armrest **16**. In other words, first armrest **14** is laterally-spaced from second armrest **16**. The method includes placing a second end (i.e., proximate the front end **14a** and inner side **14f**) of the first armrest **14** in close proximity to a second end (i.e., proximate front end **16a** and inner side **16f**) of the second armrest **16**. The second end of the first armrest **14** and the second end of the second armrest **16** are spaced a distance forwardly away from the backrest **12**. A person's back is placed in abutting contact with the front **12a** of the backrest **12**.

such that their torso is located in the space **34** defined by support pillow **10**. The person's torso is encircled by backrest **12**, first armrest **14**, and second armrest **16**. The second end or free end of the first armrest **14** and the second end or free end of the second armrest **16** are located in front of a central region of the person's abdomen.

(45) The method may further comprise detachably engaging one or both of the first end of the first armrest **14** and the first end of the second armrest **16** to the backrest. The method may include detachably securing the second end of the first armrest **14** to the second end of the second armrest **16** via the third securement mechanism **22**.

(46) Various inventive concepts may be embodied as one or more methods, of which an example has been provided. The acts performed as part of the method may be ordered in any suitable way. Accordingly, embodiments may be constructed in which acts are performed in an order different than illustrated, which may include performing some acts simultaneously, even though shown as sequential acts in illustrative embodiments.

(47) While various inventive embodiments have been described and illustrated herein, those of ordinary skill in the art will readily envision a variety of other means and/or structures for performing the function and/or obtaining the results and/or one or more of the advantages described herein, and each of such variations and/or modifications is deemed to be within the scope of the inventive embodiments described herein. More generally, those skilled in the art will readily appreciate that all parameters, dimensions, materials, and configurations described herein are meant to be exemplary and that the actual parameters, dimensions, materials, and/or configurations will depend upon the specific application or applications for which the inventive teachings is/are used. Those skilled in the art will recognize, or be able to ascertain using no more than routine experimentation, many equivalents to the specific inventive embodiments described herein. It is, therefore, to be understood that the foregoing embodiments are presented by way of example only and that, within the scope of the appended claims and equivalents thereto, inventive embodiments may be practiced otherwise than as specifically described and claimed. Inventive embodiments of the present disclosure are directed to each individual feature, system, article, material, kit, and/or method described herein. In addition, any combination of two or more such features, systems, articles, materials, kits, and/or methods, if such features, systems, articles, materials, kits, and/or methods are not mutually inconsistent, is included within the inventive scope of the present disclosure.

(48) All definitions, as defined and used herein, should be understood to control over dictionary definitions, definitions in documents incorporated by reference, and/or ordinary meanings of the defined terms.

(49) The articles “a” and “an,” as used herein in the specification and in the claims, unless clearly indicated to the contrary, should be understood to mean “at least one.” The phrase “and/or,” as used herein in the specification and in the claims (if at all), should be understood to mean “either or both” of the elements so conjoined, i.e., elements that are conjunctively present in some cases and disjunctively present in other cases. Multiple elements listed with “and/or” should be construed in the same fashion, i.e., “one or more” of the elements so conjoined. Other elements may optionally be present other than the elements specifically identified by the “and/or” clause, whether related or unrelated to those elements specifically identified. Thus, as a non-limiting example, a reference to “A and/or B”, when used in conjunction with open-ended language such as “comprising” can refer, in one embodiment, to A only (optionally including elements other than B); in another embodiment, to B only (optionally including elements other than A); in yet another embodiment, to both A and B (optionally including other elements); etc. As used herein in the specification and in the claims, “or” should be understood to have the same meaning as “and/or” as defined above. For example, when separating items in a list, “or” or “and/or” shall be interpreted as being inclusive, i.e., the inclusion of at least one, but also including more than one, of a number or list of elements, and, optionally, additional unlisted items. Only terms clearly indicated to the contrary, such as

“only one of” or “exactly one of,” or, when used in the claims, “consisting of,” will refer to the inclusion of exactly one element of a number or list of elements. In general, the term “or” as used herein shall only be interpreted as indicating exclusive alternatives (i.e. “one or the other but not both”) when preceded by terms of exclusivity, such as “either,” “one of,” “only one of,” or “exactly one of.” “Consisting essentially of,” when used in the claims, shall have its ordinary meaning as used in the field of patent law.

(50) As used herein in the specification and in the claims, the phrase “at least one,” in reference to a list of one or more elements, should be understood to mean at least one element selected from any one or more of the elements in the list of elements, but not necessarily including at least one of each and every element specifically listed within the list of elements and not excluding any combinations of elements in the list of elements. This definition also allows that elements may optionally be present other than the elements specifically identified within the list of elements to which the phrase “at least one” refers, whether related or unrelated to those elements specifically identified. Thus, as a non-limiting example, “at least one of A and B” (or, equivalently, “at least one of A or B,” or, equivalently “at least one of A and/or B”) can refer, in one embodiment, to at least one, optionally including more than one, A, with no B present (and optionally including elements other than B); in another embodiment, to at least one, optionally including more than one, B, with no A present (and optionally including elements other than A); in yet another embodiment, to at least one, optionally including more than one, A, and at least one, optionally including more than one, B (and optionally including other elements); etc.

(51) As used herein in the specification and in the claims, the term “effecting” or a phrase or claim element beginning with the term “effecting” should be understood to mean to cause something to happen or to bring something about. For example, effecting an event to occur may be caused by actions of a first party even though a second party actually performed the event or had the event occur to the second party. Stated otherwise, effecting refers to one party giving another party the tools, objects, or resources to cause an event to occur. Thus, in this example a claim element of “effecting an event to occur” would mean that a first party is giving a second party the tools or resources needed for the second party to perform the event, however the affirmative single action is the responsibility of the first party to provide the tools or resources to cause said event to occur.

(52) When a feature or element is herein referred to as being “on” another feature or element, it can be directly on the other feature or element or intervening features and/or elements may also be present. In contrast, when a feature or element is referred to as being “directly on” another feature or element, there are no intervening features or elements present. It will also be understood that, when a feature or element is referred to as being “connected”, “attached” or “coupled” to another feature or element, it can be directly connected, attached or coupled to the other feature or element or intervening features or elements may be present. In contrast, when a feature or element is referred to as being “directly connected”, “directly attached” or “directly coupled” to another feature or element, there are no intervening features or elements present. Although described or shown with respect to one embodiment, the features and elements so described or shown can apply to other embodiments. It will also be appreciated by those of skill in the art that references to a structure or feature that is disposed “adjacent” another feature may have portions that overlap or underlie the adjacent feature.

(53) Spatially relative terms, such as “under”, “below”, “lower”, “over”, “upper”, “above”, “behind”, “in front of”, and the like, may be used herein for ease of description to describe one element or feature's relationship to another element(s) or feature(s) as illustrated in the figures. It will be understood that the spatially relative terms are intended to encompass different orientations of the device in use or operation in addition to the orientation depicted in the figures. For example, if a device in the figures is inverted, elements described as “under” or “beneath” other elements or features would then be oriented “over” the other elements or features. Thus, the exemplary term “under” can encompass both an orientation of over and under. The device may be otherwise

oriented (rotated 90° or at other orientations) and the spatially relative descriptors used herein interpreted accordingly. Similarly, the terms “upwardly”, “downwardly”, “vertical”, “horizontal”, “lateral”, “transverse”, “longitudinal”, and the like are used herein for the purpose of explanation only unless specifically indicated otherwise.

(54) Although the terms “first” and “second” may be used herein to describe various features/elements, these features/elements should not be limited by these terms, unless the context indicates otherwise. These terms may be used to distinguish one feature/element from another feature/element. Thus, a first feature/element discussed herein could be termed a second feature/element, and similarly, a second feature/element discussed herein could be termed a first feature/element without departing from the teachings of the present invention.

(55) An embodiment is an implementation or example of the present disclosure. Reference in the specification to “an embodiment,” “one embodiment,” “some embodiments,” “one particular embodiment,” “an exemplary embodiment,” or “other embodiments,” or the like, means that a particular feature, structure, or characteristic described in connection with the embodiments is included in at least some embodiments, but not necessarily all embodiments, of the invention. The various appearances “an embodiment,” “one embodiment,” “some embodiments,” “one particular embodiment,” “an exemplary embodiment,” or “other embodiments,” or the like, are not necessarily all referring to the same embodiments.

(56) If this specification states a component, feature, structure, or characteristic “may”, “might”, or “could” be included, that particular component, feature, structure, or characteristic is not required to be included. If the specification or claim refers to “a” or “an” element, that does not mean there is only one of the element. If the specification or claims refer to “an additional” element, that does not preclude there being more than one of the additional element.

(57) As used herein in the specification and claims, including as used in the examples and unless otherwise expressly specified, all numbers may be read as if prefaced by the word “about” or “approximately,” even if the term does not expressly appear. The phrase “about” or “approximately” may be used when describing magnitude and/or position to indicate that the value and/or position described is within a reasonable expected range of values and/or positions. For example, a numeric value may have a value that is $\pm 0.1\%$ of the stated value (or range of values), $\pm 1\%$ of the stated value (or range of values), $\pm 2\%$ of the stated value (or range of values), $\pm 5\%$ of the stated value (or range of values), $\pm 10\%$ of the stated value (or range of values), etc. Any numerical range recited herein is intended to include all sub-ranges subsumed therein.

(58) Additionally, the method of performing the present disclosure may occur in a sequence different than those described herein. Accordingly, no sequence of the method should be read as a limitation unless explicitly stated. It is recognizable that performing some of the steps of the method in a different order could achieve a similar result.

(59) In the claims, as well as in the specification above, all transitional phrases such as “comprising,” “including,” “carrying,” “having,” “containing,” “involving,” “holding,” “composed of,” and the like are to be understood to be open-ended, i.e., to mean including but not limited to. Only the transitional phrases “consisting of” and “consisting essentially of” shall be closed or semi-closed transitional phrases, respectively.

(60) To the extent that the present disclosure has utilized the term “invention” in various titles or sections of this specification, this term was included as required by the formatting requirements of word document submissions pursuant the guidelines/requirements of the United States Patent and Trademark Office and shall not, in any manner, be considered a disavowal of any subject matter.

(61) In the foregoing description, certain terms have been used for brevity, clearness, and understanding. No unnecessary limitations are to be implied therefrom beyond the requirement of the prior art because such terms are used for descriptive purposes and are intended to be broadly construed.

(62) Moreover, the description and illustration of various embodiments of the disclosure are examples and the disclosure is not limited to the exact details shown or described.

Claims

1. A support pillow comprising: a backrest; a first armrest engageable with the backrest; a second armrest engageable with the backrest a lateral distance away from the first armrest; wherein each of the first armrest and the second armrest extends forwardly from the backrest and curves inwardly to terminate in a free end located a distance forwardly of a front of the backrest; wherein the free end of the first armrest is opposed to the free end of the second armrest; wherein the backrest, the first armrest, and the second armrest, together, encircle a space adapted to receive a torso of a person therein; a securement mechanism which detachably secures the free end of the first armrest to the free end of the second armrest; wherein one or both of the first armrest and the second armrest is detachably engageable with the backrest; wherein the first armrest and the second armrest are substantially identical to one another and are arranged as mirror images of one another relative to the backrest; and wherein each of the first armrest and the second armrest has: a top end, a bottom end, a front end, and a rear end; wherein each of the first armrest and the second armrest is of a height measured between the top end and the bottom end thereof; and wherein the height tapers moving in a direction from the rear end of the first armrest and the second armrest to the front end thereof.
2. The support pillow according to claim 1, further comprising a first securement mechanism for detachably securing one of the first armrest and the second armrest to the backrest.
3. The support pillow according to claim 2, further comprising a second securement mechanism for detachably securing the other of the first armrest and the second armrest to the backrest.
4. The support pillow according to claim 1, wherein the backrest has a depth measured between the front and a rear thereof, and wherein the depth tapers moving in a direction from a bottom of the backrest to a top of the backrest.
5. The support pillow according to claim 1, wherein the front of the backrest is oriented at an angle of from about 75° up to about 85° relative to a bottom of the backrest.
6. The support pillow according to claim 5, wherein a rear of the backrest is oriented at 90° relative to a bottom of the backrest.
7. The support pillow according to claim 1, further comprising a handle provided on the backrest.
8. The support pillow according to claim 1, wherein the top end of each of the first armrest and the second armrest is oriented at an angle of from about 75° up to about 85° relative to the rear end thereof.
9. The support pillow according to claim 8, wherein the rear end of the first armrest and the second armrest is oriented at 90° relative to the bottom end thereof.
10. The support pillow according to claim 1, further comprising a handle provided on one or both of the first armrest and the second armrest.
11. The support pillow according to claim 1, wherein a rear end of each of the first armrest and the second armrest is oriented at an angle of from about 190° up to about 210° relative to a back of the backrest.
12. The support pillow according to claim 1, wherein each of the first armrest and the second armrest is generally J-shaped.
13. The support pillow according to claim 1, wherein each of the first armrest and the second armrest is of a width proximate a rear end thereof, wherein the rear end is located proximate a back of the backrest, and wherein the width tapers moving from the rear end towards a front end thereof.
14. The support pillow according to claim 1, further comprising one or more pockets provided on one or more of the backrest, the first armrest, and the second armrest.
15. A method comprising: detachably engaging a first end of a first armrest with a backrest of a

support pillow; detachably engaging a first end of a second armrest with the backrest a laterally-spaced distance from the first end of the first armrest; arranging the first armrest and the second armrest as mirror images of one another relative to the backseat; wherein the first armrest and the second armrest are substantially identical to one another and each the first armrest and the second armrest has: a top end, a bottom end, a front end, and a rear end; wherein each of the first armrest and the second armrest is of a height measured between the top end and the bottom end thereof; and wherein the height tapers moving in a direction from the rear end of the first armrest and the second armrest to the front end thereof; placing a second end of the first armrest in close proximity to a second end of the second armrest a distance longitudinally forwardly of a front of the backrest; encircling a space with the backrest, the first armrest, and the second armrest; wherein the space is adapted to receive a torso of a person resting against the backrest; and detachable securing the second end of the first armrest to the second end of the second armrest with a securement mechanism.
